

Group Discussion

1 Initiating the Group Discussion: To initiate a discussion means to open the discussion. Imagine yourself as the group leader. When you initiate a group discussion, you take the opportunity to speak as well as to catch the attention of group members. It is your first impression that will help you. The most important thing you have to keep in mind is to speak clearly and freely. It will help you to show your leadership qualities. Let us study some important ways of initiating group discussion.

Stating the topic of Group Discussion: Friends, the topic of our group discussion is 'Environmental degradation and problem of livelihood in modern society'.

Making Initial Statement:

Study the following expressions:

Gentlemen, let me take an opportunity to open this discussion.

Friends, allow me to open this discussion.

Let us start with ourselves.

I feel we ourselves are unknowingly responsible for environmental degradation.

Sometimes the topic is given to us by organizers. Then, you can start group discussion in the following way.

Friends/Gentlemen, the topic given to us for discussion is 'Problem of corruption in Indian society'.

Note the following expressions which are used for making an initial statement.

In my opinion, -----.

Personally, I think that -----.

I would like to say that -----.

It is believed that -----.

I would like to point out that -----.

I feel that -----.

In my view, -----.

There are different ways of opening a discussion.

Study the following expressions.

- 1. Friends, the topic for our discussion is 'Importance of villages in the development of India'. If you want my honest opinion, it was Mahatma Gandhi who focused on the importance of village life.*
- 2. Gentlemen, allow me to start the discussion on 'A friend in need is a friend indeed'. In my view, it is the best practice to maintain healthy relationship.*
- 3. Friends, let us begin the discussion on 'India's scientific policy'. In my opinion, India's scientific policy should focus on agriculture and not on missiles.*

Check your progress I:

How will you initiate a discussion on the following topics?

1. Honesty is the best policy
2. Higher education examination system
3. Use of cell phones among college students
4. Need of bullet train in Mumbai

Inviting Comments or Eliciting Opinions:

As a group leader, you have to invite group members to participate or share their views after the declaration of the topic. It is a golden opportunity for you to show your leadership qualities. Sometimes, some group members remain inactive members. In such a situation, as a group leader, you have to motivate them to participate in discussion. At the same time you have to use tact and skill to encourage them.

Let us see some ways of inviting someone to speak in a discussion:

- 1. What's your idea about this statement, Mr. Sudhakar Patil?*
- 2. How do you react to this statement, Mr. Desai?*
- 3. Do you have anything to say about this statement, Mrs. Nirmala?*
- 4. What do you think about this statement, Neha?*
- 5. I think Mrs. Usha Patil wants to say something.*

6. *Mr. Vinayak Patil, I am eagerly waiting for your opinion regarding this statement.*

7. *Firstly, I would like to know Mr. Kalekar's opinion in this respect.*

8. *What do you feel about that statement Mrs. Sunanda Desai?*

Sometimes, you come across some members who are only mute spectators. You will have to encourage them individually to speak. To make them participate in discussion, you may say:

1. *Well, Mr. Patil, would you like to say something?*

2. *Now, I am going to Shailesh Desai to know his opinion.*

Sometimes, you have to address not a particular person but a group. You can address them in the following manner:

1. *Gentlemen, feel free to express your views regarding this issue.*

2. *Are you with me regarding this statement? If not, feel free to correct me.*

3. *Friends, any comments on this suggestion?*

Sometimes while eliciting opinions, you have to use specific words, phrases and clauses to express your strong opinions and your personal point of view.

Let us study the following examples:

1. *What I mean is that TV has badly affected the life of students.*

2. *I believe that Pakistan is a terrorist country in the world.*

3. *I would like to point out that the use of mobile phone by students is a serious problem nowadays.*

4. *I am sure that the prices of gold will come down after the formation of new government.*

Sometimes, an opinion can be expressed considering the general point of view instead of making a strong statement.

Now study the following examples:

1. *It is generally accepted that higher education examination system needs important reforms.*

2. *Some people say that our economic condition is degrading day-by-day.*
3. *It is believed that international anti-terrorist act is necessary in the world.*

Check your progress: II

Invite a group member to join the discussion by reacting to the following:

1. Implementation of annual system of examination in Arts and Commerce colleges
2. Student election in colleges
3. Role of women in government jobs
4. Increasing dropout rate of female students in rural colleges

Expressing Agreement and Disagreement:

Agreement and disagreement are inseparable aspects in a group discussion. During the course of group discussion, you may agree with a statement, suggestion, solution or sometimes disagree with it. When you agree with a specific view, be firm on your opinion. Do not be fickle-minded or indecisive. Further, whether you agree or disagree, concentrate and be firm on your opinion and avoid yawning, looking outside, lip-biting, touching hair, etc. It shows that you are nervous and indecisive.

Your agreement or disagreement depends on your thorough knowledge of the subject and your expressive skills. Sometimes, you agree partially and want to modify a given view or statement. We must also be sure of our opinion. Even when we express strong disagreements, we should take care that our words should not hurt others, i.e. we must be polite.

Study the following expressions of agreement:

1. *I agree with you 100 percent.*
2. *That's so true.*
3. *Absolutely!*
4. *Exactly!*
5. *You have a point there.*
6. *You are absolutely right.*

Note the following statement of agreement. There can be a strong agreement supporting the point of view.

As far as I am concerned, I absolutely agree with you that girls are scoring good marks in examinations.

Sometimes, there can be partial agreement with the statement made earlier.

Personally, I agree with you. But use of ICT in teaching is important for teachers.

Sometimes the speaker agrees by giving reason. The speaker reacts against absolute statement and seeks examples in support.

Let's study the following example:

Well, according to you the use of cell-phone and some mobile apps are harmful to our students. Could you give any specific examples?

In group discussion, you have to use specific structures, words and phrases to express strong agreement or partial agreement.

Note the expressions for strong and partial agreement:

Strong Agreement Partial Agreement You are absolutely right. I agree with you entirely. Yes, that is a good point. I would go along with you. I think so too. Of course, you are right. I have no doubt about your point. I don't think so either. I agree with you up to a point. I agree with you in case of two things only. Well, but we will have to examine this. It is somewhat difficult. I also think so but I am not sure it will work. You are right but what about other things. I can't agree with you fully. I want to say something different.

Strong Agreement	Partial Agreement
<i>I agree with you entirely.</i>	<i>I agree with you up to a point.</i>
<i>You are absolutely right.</i>	<i>I agree with you in case of two things only.</i>
<i>Yes, that is a good point.</i>	<i>Well, but we will have to examine this.</i>
<i>I would go along with you.</i>	<i>It is somewhat difficult.</i>
<i>I think so too.</i>	<i>I also think so but I am not sure it will work.</i>
<i>Of course, you are right.</i>	<i>You are right but what about other things.</i>

<i>I have no doubt about your point.</i>	<i>I can't agree with you fully.</i>
<i>I don't think so either.</i>	<i>I want to say something different</i>

In a group discussion or a meeting, you are free to agree or disagree. No one can impose any views or opinion on you. One thing you have to keep in mind is to avoid strong statements, loud speaking and aggressiveness and be considerate to the feelings of others while disagreeing. So, be moderate and avoid competitiveness. You have to prove your leadership qualities by tolerating the points of view of others. For your disagreement, give convincing reasons. Remember that it is a kind of brain storming session. Note the following examples:

Statements of Disagreement	Manners of Disagreement
<i>I am sorry to disagree with you. If you want to cancel GST, propose other ways of collecting tax which can't be foolish.</i>	<i>The speaker politely disagrees and insists on finding out alternate ways.</i>
<i>I am not fully convinced of your views. You can't judge all people to be blind believers. They have their own faith.</i>	<i>The speaker politely disagrees with new suggestion.</i>
<i>It is injustice on the part of students to say that they are very much crazy for internet and cell-phone. Don't you think they are very much familiar with modern technology?</i>	<i>The speaker strongly disagrees and raises question.</i>
<i>No, no. I can't agree with you. I think you are absolutely wrong because you can't judge a person by outward appearance.</i>	<i>The speaker strongly disagrees and raises question.</i>
<i>I must take issue with you on your view that rich people are becoming richer and poor poorer. During the last ten years, the poor classes have shown upward mobility.</i>	<i>The speaker vehemently disagrees, giving reason.</i>

Check your progress: III

A) Express your agreement with the following opinions, giving a reason for supporting them:

1. To save environment means to save the Earth

2. Growth of professional colleges indicates rise in the quality of private education
3. Running women education centre means doing important social work
4. To save Sanskrit language means to save Marathi culture
5. Co-education helps healthy social relationship

B) Express your disagreement, strong or partial, with the following giving your reason for it:

1. Indian television channels expose us to Indian ways of life.
2. Reservation for women in politics and jobs contribute to developing the status of women in society.

Intervening or Breaking into the Discussion:

Sometimes, group discussion reaches the highest point when all the members are fully engrossed in it. But as a group leader; you have to break into it due to various reasons. Firstly, your role is not only to listen, but also to grab an opportunity to share your own views. How do you break into the conversation? What appropriate words, phrases and expressions do you use?

Please study the following expressions:

1. *With your permission, may I add a point here?*
2. *Excuse me for intervening, what I feel is -----.*
3. *Please listen to me; I want to share my views about it.*
4. *Could you please listen to me?*
5. *May I add to what you are saying?*
6. *Friends, there can be another angle.*
7. *Sorry to interrupt, but -----.*

Sometimes, the discussion goes off the track and your duty is to bring it back to the main issue. On many occasions, you come across digression from the topic. For example, the topic is 'Implementation of GST' but some members are talking about LBT. As a group leader, it is your duty to bring them back to the main topic by intervening in the discussion in a polite manner.

Let us study the following expressions of intervening a discussion:

1. *Friends, let me break your discussion to come back to our topic.*
2. *Gentlemen, let us come back to our main point, we are talking about review of examination system.*
3. *Ok. Mr. Desai, your point is right, but it is unrelated to our present topic.*
4. *Please, let us come back to our topic of discussion.*
5. *Well gentlemen, what you are talking about is wonderful but our topic is 'Education and reservation for women'.*

Sometimes, the group members lose their temper, cool and silent discussion turns into a hot argument and results in a personal dispute. As a group leader, you have to interfere at this point and bring all the members back to the topic. How will you do this? What expressions will you use to stop the members going away from the issue? Let us study some expressions:

1. *Well, Mr. Deshmukh, I have understood your point.*
2. *Please, Mr. Naik, don't take it to mind.*
3. *Friends, be silent for a moment.*
4. *Please, Mrs. Nirmala don't get angry.*
5. *No, no Mrs. Nimkar, please pay attention to me. Let us come back to our main issue.*

Check your progress IV:

A) Intervene the discussion in the following situations:

1. There is a discussion on arrangement and plans of celebrating your friend's birthday party. Intervene into the discussion suggesting an innovative idea about the birthday celebrating.
2. There is a discussion on Annual Prize Distribution Programme about inviting a chief guest. Intervene into the discussion by pointing out the name of a famous personality.
3. Only a few alumni show their interest in Alumni Meet. Intervene into the discussion and suggest a new idea.

B) In the following situations, the discussion is diverting from its track. How will you bring it back by intervening into it?

1. The topic of discussion is girls are more sincere and regular than boys in colleges. But the members begin talking about university results in colleges.
2. A hot discussion is going on about the bad condition of roads. How will you bring it under control and make the members come back to the main topic?
3. The discussion is on changing trends in politics and religion. But members begin talking about construction of Ram Mandir.

Making Suggestions / Accepting or Refusing Suggestions:

Group discussion involves exchange of views, thoughts and suggestions. In the course of time, you may not like someone's views and opinions and you would like to make counter proposals. Sometimes, you accept the suggestions made by others but you may have doubts. You have to express your objections politely and seek clarification.

Note the following example to know what expressions are used in such situations.

Making Suggestion:

I would like to suggest that semester system of examination should be stopped and annual pattern of examination should be reintroduced.

Conditional Acceptance:

Your suggestion is worth considering but there must be some alternative to reduce the burden of entire syllabus.

Refusal:

That is absolutely a wrong idea. The semester system is introduced by University Grants Commission and implemented by state universities.

Raising Objections:

Are you sure that all the colleges will conduct internal examinations? And what about ensuring quality?

Expressing Hesitation:

Well, I'm in two minds really. I am not sure if within the first semester fifty percent syllabus can be covered.

Commenting on the Attitudes of others:

In daily life, on many occasions, we express our attitude towards others. In the same way, in group discussion also, group members express their attitude towards others. Let us study some examples:

1. *I think your attitude towards our family and family members is reflected in your statement.*
2. *In my view, your attitude towards politics is pessimistic.*
3. *Well, you need not be impatient about college gathering. We are going to conduct it in the next month.*
4. *Look, your idea is fine but it is too costly to purchase separate tabs for each girl.*
5. *I don't think you will get response from those who believe blindly.*

Presenting different alternatives or solutions to a problem:

Problem	Alternative Solution
How to prevent dropout rate of girls in colleges of rural areas?	One remedy is counseling parents and girls about the importance of education, and secondly, to introduce different value added courses.
	One solution to this problem is to establish Students' Aid Fund to help the poor and needy girls to enable them to continue their higher education.
Girls and women are becoming insecure in big cities in India.	The best solution on it is to fix CCTV cameras at important places to watch the criminals. Besides, it is necessary to censor frankness of women in TV serials, movies and at public places.
	One remedy for it is that criminals should get severe punishment so that they won't dare to do this.

Summing Up: An attractive beginning and an appropriate end are important aspects of group discussion. Any discussion has to come to an end and you have to sum up. While summing it up, you have to take stock of main points, remarks,

views, opinions, agreements, disagreements, suggestions, etc. made by members of the group in brief.

Note the following expressions for summing up the discussion:

1. *Gentlemen, excuse me but the time allotted to us is almost over. Let us sum up the main points made by you.*
2. *O.K. friends. Let me conclude this session.*
3. *Thank you gentlemen. Now, it is time to conclude the discussion.*
4. *All right then. Let me conclude this discussion. All friends discussed the topic entitled 'No-Vehicle Day' in a week in our college. Mrs. Nimkar pointed out the rising prices of fuel day-by-day. Mr. Nilesh Patil pointed out the importance of using bicycle and public transport once in a week. Mr. Sawant insisted that students should use bicycles daily for their safety and physical fitness. Mr. Desai objected to Mr. Sawant's opinion pointing out that each and every student can't purchase bicycle. Thank you friends. Let us call it a day.*

Check your progress: V

A) There is a Group Discussion on the following problems/ issues. Make suggestions on each of them giving an argument in support.

1. How to stop suicides of farmers?
2. Terrorism is a serious problem in our country.
3. A chief guest to be invited for the Book Publication Programme
4. How to stop sexual harassment of women in public places?

B) Someone in your group suggests that the college trip should be arranged before terminal examination instead of in February and March.

- a) Support this suggestion making your own point.
- b) Oppose this suggestion giving your reason.
- c) Express your doubts about the feasibility of the suggestion.

Summary:

Group discussion is a complex skill. You should be able to use English for stating your opinion, expressing your agreement or disagreement, taking initiative in the

discussion, giving your reactions, offering suggestions, and so on. In a group discussion your general knowledge, your ability to convince others, your skill in handling discussion are tested. There are various expressions in this unit, which students have to master to be able to take part in a group discussion effectively.

4 Key to Check your Progress:

I:1. Honesty is the best policy Friends, the topic for discussion given to us is Honesty is the best policy. Please, allow me to open the discussion. In my opinion, honesty in life is very important on the backdrop of widespread corruption in every walk of life.

2. Higher education examination system Friends we have to discuss the topic Higher education examination system. I think Higher education examination system is outdated and it should be modified and improved.

3. Use of cell phones among college students Friends we are here to discuss the topic: Use of cell phones among college students. I feel that cell phones should be used for academic purpose but college student spend unnecessary time on Facebook and WhatsApp surfing.

4. Need of bullet train in Mumbai Friends, the interview committee want us to discuss the topic Need of bullet train in Mumbai. Let me initiate this discussion. I believe this craze for bullet train is a politically motivated view. Instead, I feel the condition of local trains should be improved.

II: 1. *Mr. Sudhakar Patil, what would you say about implementation of annual system of examination in Arts and Commerce colleges? Is annual system of examination useful in arts and commerce colleges?*

2. *Mr. Dhanaji Desai, how do you react to student election in colleges? Is it necessary for the development of students?*

3. *Mr. Shailesh do you agree that the role of women in government jobs is required? Is their role in administration genuine?*

4. *Mrs. Sunanda, what do you say about the increasing dropout rate of female students in rural colleges?*

III: A) Express your agreement

1. *This is absolutely true. To save environment means to save the Earth. Due to environmental degradation people are suffering from the problems like the Green House effect.*
2. *I quite agree with this. The growth of professional colleges indicates rise in the quality of private education because they are using ICT in education.*
3. *I have no doubt about it. Running women education centre means doing important social work. Educated women can change their home and way of life.*
4. *I quite agree with this. To save Sanskrit language means to save Marathi culture because the role of language is important in culture.*
5. *This is absolutely true. Co-education helps healthy social relationship in society because ultimately when it comes to social life men and women have to live together.*

B) Express your disagreement:

1. *I do not agree with the view that Indian television channels expose us to Indian ways of life. Rather they blindly show the foreign ways of life.*
2. *I don't really think reservation for women in politics and jobs can contribute to developing the status of women in society. On the contrary women's education should be promoted, encouraged. Their hard work and sincerity will help them win good jobs and carve a place for themselves in politics too.*

IV: A) Intervene in the discussion in the following situations.

1. *Listen to me please. I have an idea. Let us give a book as a birthday gift and distribute plants to participants at the birthday party.*
2. *Let us come back to our original topic. We are talking about Annual Prize Distribution Programme and a chief guest and not about cinema celebrities.*
3. *If you please, let me have a word on this. Do you see how students are burdened with family responsibilities and job responsibilities?*

B) In the following situations, the discussion is diverting from its track. How will you bring it back by intervening into it?

1. *Excuse me, please, but I think we are digressing from our topic. We are discussing the topic, "girls are more sincere and regular than boys in colleges" and not university results in colleges.*

2. *Gentlemen, let us come back to our topic. We are discussing "the bad condition of roads" and not about contractors.*

3. *Friends, we are wandering away from our topic. It is not about construction of Ram Mandir but "trends in politics and religion".*

V: A) Making suggestions by giving an argument in support.

1. *It is necessary to find out solution on farmers making suicides. Government should give loans charging low interest and take some steps for counseling of farmers.*

2. *Terrorism is a serious problem in our country and government should take strong action against terrorists. The Defence Ministry should seriously think about young generation being lured into terrorism.*

3. *I suggest a well-known dramatist should be invited as chief guest for Book Publication Programme because last year we had invited a great novelist for the function.*

4. *One solution is that police should take strong action to stop sexual harassment of women in public places and CC TV cameras should be put up at public places.*

B) The college trip should be arranged before terminal examination instead of in February and March

a) *I appreciate this suggestion. The college trips are often disrupted by stormy rains, or there is unbearable heat.*

b) *Before terminal examination means in October/November? These are months of festivals. This suggestion cannot be accepted.*

c) *I have serious doubt about arranging college trips before terminal examination. Arranging trips in the month of Jan/Feb is convenient for students and teachers also.*

Exercises:

1. Complete the following Group Discussion according to the notes in the table.
(You may have to supply complete sentences, clauses or phrases)

A: Friends, ----- is ----- . As you know, ----- is the most -----	How to stop corruption. Gives background. Calls for views.
---	--

problem before our society. I ----- your views on ----- .	
B: ----- not possible ----- corruption, because ----- .	States his opinion and reason.
C: ----- rather pessimistic ----- --- start with ourselves. If we decide --- ----- that can be a good beginning. What -----, Mr. D?	Comments on B's views. Suggests, invites opinion.
D: ----- ought to be a campaign. ----- one man's job.	Expresses hesitation. States his opinion.
B: -----.	Agrees with D
A: Mr. C, ----- explain how --- ----- ourselves?	Seeks clarification politely.
C: Well, suppose 'B' here ----- ----- a certificate, and the concerned clerk ----- -- some money, he should -----to pay.	Explains giving example.
B: And lose my job? In practice, everyone -----because ----- ---.	Objects and gives reason
D: I ----- Mr. C in this. We ----- -some kind of sacrifice. Otherwise ----- no right to ----- ----- against corruption. Supports C, explains.	Supports C, explains.